



United States
Attorney's Office
Western District of Pennsylvania



Three Leaders of Primary Health Network Plead Guilty to Defrauding Non-Profit Medical Organization of Millions of Dollars

Friday, November 14, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Western District of
Pennsylvania

This release was issued following the 43-day government shutdown during which the pleas occurred.

PITTSBURGH, Pa. – Two former Chief Executive Officers and a former facility manager for Primary Health Network (PHN) have pleaded guilty in federal court to charges of agreeing to defraud their former employer, Acting United States Attorney Troy Rivetti announced.

Drew Pierce, 58, of West Middlesex, Pennsylvania; Jack Laeng, 72, of Lake Milton, Ohio; and Mark Marriott, 58, of Sharpsville, Pennsylvania, pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit wire fraud and conspiracy to commit money laundering before United States District Judge J. Nicholas Ranjan, with Marriott also pleading guilty to willfully filing a false tax return. Laeng's plea occurred on September 25, 2025, Marriott's on October 6, 2025, and Pierce's on October 31, 2025.

In connection with the guilty pleas, the Court was advised that PHN was a non-profit organization in Sharon, Pennsylvania, that provided medical services to patients in underserved parts of Pennsylvania, regardless of their ability to pay. From approximately July 2015 through January 2019, Pierce served as CEO of PHN, Laeng as former CEO, and Marriott as the company's facilities manager. The three defendants and others agreed to insert a company called TopCoat, which they owned, between PHN and third parties, with TopCoat paying the third party for providing a service for PHN, then billing PHN a higher amount so that TopCoat could profit. Marriott caused fraudulent invoices to be issued from TopCoat to PHN, purporting that TopCoat had done work when it in fact had not. Pierce, Laeng, Marriott, and others split the profits—the difference between what PHN paid TopCoat and what TopCoat paid the third parties—among themselves, including by issuing checks from the TopCoat bank account to

themselves or other entities they controlled. On one deal alone in 2017, TopCoat received more than \$200,000 additional from PHN than what it paid the true vendor on a project.

Pierce, Laeng, and others also agreed to defraud PHN through a separate scheme in which the conspirators caused PHN to enter into contracts with a third party in exchange for the third party paying 50% of the fees received to an entity controlled by Pierce, Laeng, and their co-conspirator. In all, Pierce, Laeng and their co-conspirator received more than \$1.7 million in kickback payments from the third party between 2013 and 2020, the proceeds of which they split among themselves.

Judge Ranjan scheduled sentencings for March 9, 2026, for Pierce; March 16, 2026, for Laeng; and March 17, 2026, for Marriott. The law provides for a total sentence of up to 20 years in prison, a fine of up to \$250,000 or twice the gain from the offense, or both on the offense of conspiracy to commit wire fraud, and up to a 10 year sentence of imprisonment, a fine of up to \$250,000 or twice the amount involved in the offense on the offense, or both on the money laundering conspiracy offense. Marriott faces a potential additional three years of imprisonment and fine of up to \$250,000 for the tax offense.

Under the federal Sentencing Guidelines, the actual sentence imposed is based upon the seriousness of the offenses and the prior criminal history, if any, of the defendants.

Assistant United States Attorney William B. Guappone is prosecuting this case on behalf of the government.

The Federal Bureau of Investigation and Internal Revenue Service–Criminal Investigation conducted the investigation that led to the prosecution of Pierce, Laeng, and Marriott.

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